

Founder Forum Market Research Brief

The BRIMM · research run 20261001T235023Z-2e8b · completed 2 October 2026 · prepared for Sallie Ogden

What this is. A portable summary of a market research run on who buys growth help like Founder Forum, what they want, what they fear, and the words they use. It is written so a person or another AI system can use it as context without the original files.

How to read the labels. Every finding carries one label. **[OBSERVED]**: someone said it, and the source is listed in the appendix. **[INFERRED]**: a conclusion drawn from cited evidence; nobody said it outright. **[ASSUMPTION]**: a gap filled to keep the plan usable; it needs testing, and the test is named. Source IDs: R = a Reddit post or comment, T = a Trustpilot page, G = Google autocomplete, OB1 = one prospect sales call, GT1 = the business's own facts.

Rules for anyone using this brief to write copy. No income or results guarantees. The 10x return is a target only. Client results (\$280K, \$56K to \$1M, seven-figure years) and testimonials cannot be stated as fact until records and permissions exist. Reddit quotes are anonymous public voices, never testimonials. The prospect's words (OB1) are not for marketing. Never use 'boss babe', 'girlboss' or 'hustle harder'. Voice: direct, practical, positive, never harsh, no fluff.

1. The answer in one page

- **Who to prioritise:** owners of established, customer-backed businesses whose revenue has been stuck at about the same number for a year or more, and who can't pin down why. [OBSERVED R31, R32, R33, R37, R14]
- **Lead message:** "You've been stuck at the same number, and it isn't for lack of effort." The proof is an operator who has run companies reading her actual numbers to find the one move. The payoff is profit and a fair paycheck. [INFERRED; lead needs owner confirmation]
- **The 'more work, not less' objection:** it does not appear in the public conversation. 'One more thing', 'less busy' and 'on my plate' each appear 0 times in 2,473 documents. What owners fear is paying for nothing: 'mostly vibes', 'a google doc with a 90 day plan I couldve made myself', 'you're paying for someone's time, not their results'. [OBSERVED R01, R07]
- **What makes help feel like relief:** it starts from her real books and names one move, it is hands-on, its fee is tied to a measurable result, and it has an end point. Founder Forum's terms (month-1 diagnosis, support between calls, a \$1,500 success fee measured from her books, exit any time) already do all four. The relief is in the terms, not in a promise of less work. [INFERRED R13, R23, R03, R06, R17]
- **Words to avoid leading with:** 'accountability, mindset, clarity' lands 'in the same pile as generic linkedin gurus' (R26). Don't talk to her as 'a creative who knew nothing about business' (R22). 'Relief' appears 0 times, and 'maxed out' and 'growth plan' once each.
- **Channels:** no measured evidence. Trust in this category travels by referral (R48), Reddit is hostile to coaches (R10), and creative communities are mostly hobby sellers below \$100K (R49). That supports past clients, referrals and warm conversations first, with Meta kept to a capped hook test. [INFERRED, low]

2. Business snapshot (the owner's facts)

These come from the business itself (GT1), not from the research.

- **Offer:** Founder Forum, a six-month small-group program for 8-10 women business owners. Each gets a written growth plan built from her goals, numbers and operations, then hands-on help carrying it out.
- **Delivery:** two one-hour group calls a month on Zoom, on the **second and fourth Wednesday** (corrected by the owner on 2 October 2026; the business notes say Monday). Support between calls by WhatsApp and email, plus access to recommended contractors (accountant, bookkeeper and others). First group starts 14 October 2026.
- **Phases:** month 1 diagnose and plan; months 2-3 execute, track and adjust; months 4-6 build process and support.
- **Price:** \$1,000 a month for six months (\$6,000), plus a \$1,500 success fee only if she hits the goal agreed at the start, measured from her books under a signed agreement. She can leave any time with no further payments; the current month isn't refunded. The exit is currently verbal only.
- **Does not:** do done-for-you work, serve idea-stage businesses, give bookkeeping, tax or legal advice, guarantee sales or income, offer unlimited private coaching, or source new contractors.
- **Founder:** Sallie Ogden. About 22 years as an entrepreneur; CEO-for-hire at six companies over seven years; CEO of a law firm; led a sales team of about 300; ten years in labor and employment litigation; eight years coaching; author of Hitting Rock Middle (USA Today top 25, 2021; Amazon business bestseller); host of The Sallie Ogden Show.
- **Goal:** 7 members by 14 October, about 26 active by mid-December. Selling window is now to 15 December. Ads are capped at \$2,500 a month, and the plan should not depend on cold outreach.
- **Owner preferences (learned 2 October 2026):** Sallie does not hold calls with prospects' spouses and won't try to convince them. Prospect materials should be sales-oriented and persuasive, written to the owner.

3. Coverage and confidence

Measure	Value
Status	full (depth route: discussions-only). Overall confidence: medium
Collection	last30days collector (Reddit, YouTube, Hacker News), plus a depth pass through the Arctic Shift Reddit archive (Reddit blocks this host directly)
Read in depth	36 Reddit threads, 2,473 posts and comments, from 1,743 candidates over 37 queries
Window	Reddit archive 2025-01-01 to 2026-10-02 (about 21 months, wider than 30 days because this market's conversation is low-volume); collector 2026-07-03 to 2026-10-01
Reviews	4 Trustpilot pages with reviews (summaries only, not used as buyer language). G2, Capterra and Yelp refused; Vistage and Strategic Coach have 0 reviews
Own-buyer evidence	1 prospect call (jewelry, 24 Sept 2026). No customer interviews
Not reached	X, TikTok, Instagram (no credentials); YouTube comments (bot-gated); search volume (no tool); interior-designer pro communities
Excluded	Threads astroturfed by one coaching firm (R10), and a disguised ad (R51)

Where it is thin. Most posters don't state gender or location, so 'women at \$100K+ in the US' comes from the business, not the evidence; English sources don't establish geography. Women-specific evidence is three r/Femalefounders posts plus the prospect call. Established creative owners were not found. Channel and sizing findings are not measured. Confidence: high on the trust gap; medium on the plateau and operator desires; low on women-specific, creative-specific, spouse and busy-season findings.

4. The desire map (ranked)

Scores are 1-9 judgements against the evidence. The ranking weights urgency, reachability and fit over raw scope because this is pre-launch with a short selling window. No demand proxy exists for any desire (no search-volume tool was reachable).

Rank	Desire (market words)	Scope / urgency / staying	Intensity	Fit for Founder Forum
1	D2 stuck at the same revenue for years and can't pin down why ("stuck", "plateau", "revenue ceiling")	7 / 6 / 7	keep-me-up-a t-night	Strong. Month 1 diagnoses from her goals, numbers and operations. The ground truth names the levers (marketing, pricing, repeat purchases, sales process, capacity), and market evidence says the stated problem is often not the real one (R23). Founder Forum cannot guarantee the result (no income guarantees).
2	D1 someone who's actually done it, to sanity-check my decisions ("operator", not a "grifter")	6 / 6 / 6	keep-me-up-a t-night	Strong on proof. Sallie's credentials as stated in the ground truth (CEO-for-hire at 6 companies over 7 years, law-firm CEO, led a ~300-rep sales team, ~22 years as an entrepreneur) match the 'has actually done it' bar. The buyer may want same-industry experience (R02), which a mixed group does not offer, though R23 argues most problems are generic.
3	D4 profit and a fair paycheck, not just revenue ("profit", "paycheck")	5 / 5 / 7	annoyance	Good. The ground truth says the program turns growth into better owner pay and an easier business, and pricing is a named lever (also R42 'charge more'). No income guarantees.
4	D3 get out of the weeds, stop being the bottleneck ("in the weeds", "bottleneck", "firefighting")	6 / 6 / 8	keep-me-up-a t-night	Partial. Months 4-6 build process and support so progress depends less on her. But there are no done-for-you services, and the market's 'off my plate' language (R47) partly means someone doing the work. The contractor network covers only part of that. Leading with relief from workload risks promising what months 1-3 do not deliver.
5	D5 not doing it alone ("lonely", "too solo", "sounding board")	4 / 3 / 7	must-be-nice	Good. Groups of 8-10. A supporting benefit, not a lead.

D2: Break through the number the business has been stuck at, by finding what is actually holding it there.

Quote: "I've been stuck at \$200k in revenue for three years now" (R31, R32, R33)

Why-chain: I want help growing my business [OBSERVED R11] → because revenue has been flat for years despite more effort [OBSERVED R31,R37] → because I can't pin down what is wrong [OBSERVED R14] → so my hard work isn't turning into money I keep [INFERRED R36,R41] → so I'm not sure what I built will ever give me the security I started it for [INFERRED R35,R32]

Hell: Another December looking at the same annual number, again. She has launched new products, posted more, tried another channel, and still loses a customer for every one she gains (R31). Her calendar is fuller than ever, but when she looks at the month nothing has moved (R37).

Heaven: She knows which one change moved the number: a price, a repeat-purchase program, a sales step. She can point to it in her books, and the business finally pays her a fair wage (R19).

D1: Have an experienced operator look at the business and say plainly what to do next.

Quote: "I don't have a clear, actionable plan to get there, and I don't have anyone experienced enough around me to sanity-check my decisions." (R11, R02, R25)

Why-chain: I want an advisor who has run a business [OBSERVED R25,R02] → because advice from people who haven't done it was useless to me [OBSERVED R01,R20] → because I need my decisions checked by someone who has seen this before [OBSERVED R11] → because alone I second-guess myself [OBSERVED R21] → so I can make the big calls with confidence instead of guessing [INFERRED R21,R24]

Hell: She pays \$800 a month for six months and ends up with a Google doc she could have written herself, plus calls where the coach mostly takes notes (R01).

Heaven: Someone who has run companies reads her numbers, names the move, and is there when she is unsure whether to take the wholesale order or hire.

Lead, policy and plateau plan

Lead: Lead with D2: 'you have been stuck at the same number, and it is not for lack of effort'. Make D1 (an operator who has run companies reads your actual numbers) the mechanism and proof, and D4 (profit and a fair paycheck) the payoff.

Why: Pre-launch, with a first-group target of 7 by Oct 14, ads capped at \$2,500/month and no cold outreach. So urgency, reachability and product fit outrank raw scope. D3 has comparable scope and urgency, but Founder Forum serves it only partly in the first three months (no done-for-you), so it fails gate 3 as a lead.

Plateau plan: If the plateau angle stops converting, vary the expression first (new hooks on the same desire). Then move to D4 (profit and paycheck), then D3 (out of the weeds) with honest month 4-6 framing.

Needs confirmation: a person should confirm the lead before money goes behind it.

5. Phrase bank (verbatim buyer language)

How they name the problem

"stuck at \$200k in revenue for three years" (R31) · "I keep circling the same problem" (R11) · "running on a treadmill at full speed but staying in the exact same spot" (R37) · "Busy wasn't the same as growing" (R38) · "something's off, growth's stalled, margins are weird" (R14) · "I'm still the bottleneck" (R11) · "I sometimes get stuck in the weeds" (R18) · "break through the revenue ceiling" (R32) · "scaling when hitting a time/ cash flow ceiling" (R28) · "I can't trust someone else to do my work" (R40) · "It's lonely as a small business owner" (R21)

How they describe the failed alternative

"A google doc with a 90 day plan I couldve made myself" (R01) · "is it mostly vibes?" (R01) · "more like televangelists than actual operators" (R11) · "a glorified personal journaler" (R08) · "you're paying for someone's time, not their results" (R07) · "approaching it like I was a creative who knew nothing about business" (R22) · "can't justify a \$500+/mo retainer for something I can't tell is working" (R44)

How they describe success

"a 17.5% net profit while taking a fair paycheck of over 75k" (R19) · "I can track a significant increase in my revenue" (R02) · "maintain the 10,000 foot view" (R18) · "when the business runs itself" (R43) · "take a big chunk of it off my plate" (R47)

Category words and counts (2,473 documents)

stuck 64 · profit 81 · mentor 54 · accountability 38 · bottleneck 21 · operator 16 · scam 16 · plateau 12 · ceiling 10. **Not found:** 'one more thing', 'less busy', 'relief', 'boss babe', 'girlboss' (0 each). **Barely present:** 'growth plan', 'maxed out', 'not ready' (1 each). Absence from this sample is not proof buyers never say these words.

6. Avatar A1: the owner stuck at the same number

Evidence status: hypothesis (36 public discussions plus one prospect call; no customer validation).

Stage: considering.

Field	Content
Persona	This is for a woman running an established business with customers that has been stuck at about the same revenue for a year or more, who has already tried more marketing, new products, DIY research and perhaps a coach, and who needs to see that the person helping has actually run and grown companies, and that the fee is tied to results, before buying.
Trigger	Another year at the same number (R31, R33), or about to make a big bet such as wholesale, PR or an agency (R24, R32, OB1).
Failed alternatives	More marketing, SEO and new products (R31, R33); ChatGPT/Claude; free SCORE mentors (R16); coaches with no operating record (R01, R20); consultants who didn't understand the business (R22).
Awareness	Problem-aware ('stuck'), and solution-aware of coaching but distrustful. Basis: R01, R10, R11.
Proof path	Operator track record (R02, R25, R34); specific, measurable outcomes (R06); referrals from people she trusts (R48); a low-commitment trial (R05).
Angle	The argument is that being stuck at the same number for years is rarely an effort problem, it is one unidentified lever in her own numbers, so this owner can find and pull the move that matters without paying for another round of generic advice or doing more of everything.
Offer frame	The offer frames Founder Forum as paying for results, not time (a monthly fee with exit any time, plus a success fee only if she hits the goal measured from her books), because the first group starts Oct 14 and the fall is when her numbers move [ASSUMPTION: the fall urgency is the owner's view].
Hook promise	The opening promises recognition of her exact situation ('same revenue three years running, more effort every year') through plain founder-voice copy, without promising growth or naming the program first.
Format	Founder-voice text (email, post) or short talking-head video [ASSUMPTION].
Funnel stage	Considering (warm network and referrals) first; cold second.
Language	US English, plain and direct: 'stuck', 'plateau', 'revenue ceiling', 'bottleneck', 'in the weeds', 'profit', 'mentor'. Avoid 'boss babe' and hype.
Belief shift	Currently believes 'coaches are people who couldn't make it running an actual business' (R01) and, per the owner, that growth means working harder (GT1). Must believe 'someone who has run companies will read my actual numbers and show me the one move'.
Identity	Before: 'very good at creating... not the best at business things' (R18). After: an owner who knows her numbers and runs the business like a CEO.

Field	Content
Pain / desire ladder	Surface: flat revenue. Deeper: working harder for less, paying everyone but herself (R36, R41). Deepest: what she built feels like something she is chained to (R35). Desire ladder: break through the number, then profit and a fair paycheck (R19), then a business that runs without her in every decision (R43).
Emotion / cost of inaction	Frustrated, exhausted, alone (R31, R37, R21). Cost of inaction: another flat year, and burnout (R35).
Value sensitivity (hypothesis)	Hypothesis: she will pay \$800+/month but resents generic output (R01). A retainer she can't measure is a non-starter (R44). She compares against free SCORE and AI (R16) and prefers help with an end point (R17). The success fee and exit terms are likely enabling, not a barrier.

Sub-avatars (angles on the same decision)

- **A1-S1** Trigger: Weighing a big move (wholesale, PR, an agency, a new channel). Angle: Before you spend on the big move, find out which move your numbers support. (R24, R32, OB1)
- **A1-S2** Trigger: Exhausted and the bottleneck in everything. Angle: Busy isn't growing; one plan, two calls a month (honest about months 4-6 for the 'runs without me' part). (R11, R37, R40)
- **Excluded:** early-stage Etsy and jewelry sellers, who dominate those communities, are below the fit line (R49, R50).

7. Objections and what answers them

Surface objection	The real one underneath	Answer type	What answers it
Business coaches are a scam / grifters. [OBSERVED]	I'll pay for vibes and still have to figure it out myself.	proof object + mechanism	Show what she gets in month 1 (a plan built from her own numbers) and who builds it (an operator record, specifics). Avoid 'accountability / mindset / clarity' language (R26).
They haven't run a business like mine. [OBSERVED]	They won't understand my business and will waste my time.	mechanism + FAQ	Start from her books and goals before advising. FAQ on why cross-industry peers help (R23, R30).
I can't justify it / can't tell if it's working. [OBSERVED]	There is no way to see the return.	risk reversal	Success fee only if she hits the goal measured from her books; leave any time with no further payments. No ROI guarantee.
I can get advice free (SCORE, ChatGPT). [OBSERVED]	Free advice doesn't make me act on it.	mechanism + comparison FAQ	Execution support between calls; plan, track and adjust in months 2-3.
I can't add one more thing / wait until I'm less busy. [ASSUMPTION]	(inferred) more work with no payoff	offer structure + FAQ	Two one-hour calls a month; month 1 is diagnosis; the busy season is when the numbers to diagnose exist.
Let me talk to my husband. [INFERRED]	The spouse-investor needs a low-risk case.	proof object	A one-page spouse summary: terms, exit any time, success fee only on results, what month 1 produces.
I'm a creative, not a business person. [OBSERVED]	Don't talk down to me.	copy guidance	Talk to her as an owner who built this, not a creative who needs teaching.

8. Alternatives and market gaps

What buyers use instead

- Doing more of the same (SEO, sales training, new products, more posting) is the incumbent. [OBSERVED R31, R33, R44]
- Free mentors through SCORE / SBDC are the most-recommended substitute; experiences range from 'absolutely terrible' to 'really helpful'. [OBSERVED R16, R47]
- AI as a free strategist (ChatGPT / Claude) is proposed in most help threads, with the counterpoint that it cannot hold anyone accountable. [OBSERVED R15]
- Fractional CFOs, consultants and accountants offer numbers-first strategy. [OBSERVED R04, R13]
- Self-organised peer groups. [OBSERVED R27, R30]
- Large coaching brands are known for big promises, high-pressure sales and an absent founder. [OBSERVED T02, T04, R20]

Gaps, by type

Type	Gap
trust gap	The category is distrusted, so answer with proof objects (operator record, books-measured success fee), not features. [OBSERVED]
positioning gap	Most coaching speaks 'accountability, mindset, clarity'. 'Pay for results, not time' and 'find the one move in your numbers' are open. [INFERRED]
education gap	Owners assume the fix is more marketing when it may be pricing, retention or capacity. [OBSERVED]
distribution gap	Established creative owners are not visible in creative communities, and Reddit punishes coach promotion. Warm and referral channels look like the reachable path. [INFERRED]
product gap	Some buyers want work taken off their plate. Founder Forum offers referrals, not doing the work, so don't imply otherwise. [INFERRED]

9. Test matrix (ranked by what each would teach)

#	Variable	Cell	Proves it wrong
TM1	angle	Warm list and past-client email / 1:1 message: 'stuck at the same number' plateau angle vs 'pay for results, not time' success-fee angle. Same offer, same audience. Send each to half the warm list by Oct 7.	Neither angle produces a discovery call from the warm list within 5 business days, or the two do not differ.
TM2	channel	A specific referral ask to past clients ('who do you know who's been stuck at the same revenue?') vs continuing Meta at the current spend. Count discovery calls per channel for 10 days.	Referral asks produce zero calls in 10 days while Meta produces at least one.
TM3	proof	On discovery calls, give spouse-decision prospects a one-page spouse summary (terms, exit, success fee, month-1 output) vs no summary. Track decisions within 7 days of the call.	Prospects who get the summary decide no faster than those who don't.
TM4	hook	Meta (inside the \$2,500 cap): a plateau hook in owners' words ('same revenue three years running?') vs the current creative. Two weeks, equal budget.	No difference in booked-call rate after equal spend.
TM5	objection measurement	Log every objection verbatim on calls (see RL4). Tally by Oct 14.	The busy-season objection appears on under a third of calls.

10. Open questions (cheapest test first)

- The buyer is mostly women creatives at \$100K+. **Test:** Pull the last 10 discovery calls and past clients: count industry, revenue band, and whether the plateau trigger applies. The public corpus cannot answer this.
- What tipped Sarah K. and Fraulein Boots to buy (unknown). **Test:** A 15-minute 'why did you say yes' call with each; record verbatim.
- Busy-season objection frequency. **Test:** TM5.
- Testimonials and the \$280K and \$56K->\$1M results become usable proof. **Test:** Gather records and permissions; until then they cannot be used as fact.
- Demand size. **Test:** Run Google Keyword Planner or Trends from a normal browser for 'business coach for women entrepreneurs', 'how to scale a small business', 'small business growth plan'. Record provider, geography, window and exclusions.
- Interior designers' business conversation was not reached. **Test:** Search Houzz Pro / designer Facebook groups by hand, or ask two past interior-designer clients what they read.

11. Materials already made from this research

- **Investment one-pager** (Claude doc, 2 October 2026): a sales-oriented page written to the prospect for sharing with whoever has a say. It covers what she buys (the one move, an operator, help executing it), the investment table, the 10x target, exit any time, why now, Sallie's record, and a reserve-your-seat call to action. No spouse calls. Open items: put the exit in the signed agreement; add the booking link.

Appendix: sources cited

Reddit items were read through the Arctic Shift archive; each URL points to the original thread or comment. Excerpts are verbatim and trimmed for length.

ID	Where	Excerpt
R01	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/	spent \$800/month on a 'business coach' for 6 months. here's what I got. :: A google doc with a 90 day plan I couldve made myself and 3 zoom calls where she mostly asked me questions and took notes. I think the coaching industry for small business owners is mostly people who couldn't make it running an actual business,...
R02	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9l36lp/	I have a fantastic coach. I can track a significant increase in my revenue to my time working with them. But I pay them alot more per month and they successfully ran the same type of business I am in to a multi-seven figure scale with a good profit margin. Coaching isn't useless. Paying people money who have no exper...
R03	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9ksyx7/	Yeah the industry is unregulated garbage. If they're not hands-on involved in your business, you can probably get the advice elsewhere for free.
R04	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9ksr7x/	OP I own a consulting firm and we charge far more than that. We operate from a fractional CFO standpoint but I've found without coaching my clients won't execute on our strategy. Unfortunately, there are far too many people that call themselves coaches and 'implementors' that muddy the water of actual help for small ...
R05	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9m679a/	I searched for "business coach for creatives" (I run a design agency). Looked through websites, followed social media content, read their content, and chose one that aligned with my values. I signed up for a month of service to try it out and was really happy to I stayed on.
R06	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9wa1yw/	My advice is to never pay a coach unless they are delivering a specific outcome with a measurable benefit. How else will you hold them accountable for what you've paid for. So my question would be what was the outcome you needed them to help you achieve, or what did you actually pay for?
R07	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/oczxpee/	The coaching industry has a real accountability problem these days - you're paying for someone's time, not their results. My recommendation is to find other successful business owners in your industry and start networking. You'll learn best from people who are actually in the trenches. \$800/month for a Google doc is...
R08	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/oeomtp2/	honest take — questions, notes, 90-day plan is actually what coaching is supposed to look like. The idea is that you do the thinking, they just structure it. Whether that's worth \$800/month is a different conversation. where I think it breaks down is accountability without expertise. If your coach hasn't actually run a...
R09	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rpdaek/comment/o9mb5gl/	Yeah totally! I feel like I could do something similar (excluding social media marketing - that's not my area of expertise). Honestly looking back, I would have totally paid someone like you to review my business and give me helpful tips. It took trial and error, talking to other business owners and researching inform...
R10	r/smallbusiness 2025-04-12 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1jxig8f/comment/mmr0m8h/	Jesus Christ can we ban posts about business coaches? They are all just astroturfing attempts by Denver Business Coaches. There's literally one every other day. I wish they realized how obvious and embarrassing it is for them. [note: commenter calling out astroturfing; used as evidence of category distrust only]

ID	Where	Excerpt
R11	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-30 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1valsnd/	Struggling to get out of the weeds and actually grow. Looking for a business coach who isn't a grifter :: I run a construction/remodeling company as a licensed GC. Been at it for a while, the business is profitable, but I'm stuck doing work I know I shouldn't be doing myself. I'm still the bottleneck for hiring, sales,...
R12	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-30 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1valsnd/comment/p0mf1kl/	Business coaches are a scam wrapped in a marketing pitch and in the construction industry in particular they love to prey on companies since construction companies, especially these days with the rise of PE interest in the industry. You're best off taking classes at a college or online resources. Don't fall for the del...
R13	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-30 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1valsnd/comment/p0nyop9/	I'm an accountant and I work with business strategy from a financial perspective. We start with your books as they are currently and look for missed opportunities or overspending. Then sit down with you and ask the 'why' behind them. It's usually easy to pinpoint but always a struggle for an owner to let go of control...
R14	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-28 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1v95kl2/	How do you figure out what's actually wrong with your business when you can't afford a \$5K consultant? :: Been thinking about this a lot — talked to a few owners lately who all had the same feeling: something's off, growth's stalled, margins are weird, whatever — but they can't pin down *what*, and a real strategist is...
R15	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-28 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1v95kl2/comment/p0d1a20/	The other thing that Claude can't do is actually keep you accountable when you don't do the things Claude asked you to do. People only respect the decisions that they personally make and unless the tool asks the right questions that allow you make the right decision for yourself then you aren't going to fully buy in ...
R16	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-28 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1v95kl2/comment/p0b58yq/	find a SCORE mentor through your local SBDC office. They are free consultants through the SBA. You could also see if there are industry events to talk to business owners outside of your region and/or see if that organization does any benchmark reports.
R17	r/smallbusiness 2025-09-08 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1nbeya6/comment/nd1bv7/	Probably not. But if you do go that route, try to get somebody on for a “project” or similar language that has an end to it. Because I have learned the hard way how much an ongoing consultant expense can add up to
R18	r/smallbusiness 2026-01-17 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1qf03xk/comment/o03q4vm/	I am very good at creating and producing my personalized products. Have won many awards for quality and design. However, I am not the best at business things. Has helped me set up better accounting, marketing and other priorities. He holds me accountable to get things done for the business. I meet with him one on one o...
R19	r/smallbusiness 2026-01-17 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1qf03xk/comment/o01jwrr/	I have a business coach and he has helped me turn my business from doing a liitle over break even to now running a 17.5% net profit while taking a fair paycheck of over 75k.
R20	r/smallbusiness 2026-01-17 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1qf03xk/comment/o01s6ze/	Yes, I did. I hired a former Tony Robbins "certified coach." I wish I had taken everything I had paid him and put it in an S&P 500 mutual fund. It would have been much more beneficial to me.
R21	r/Entrepreneur 2026-09-23 https://www.reddit.com/r/Entrepreneur/comments/1wo3oud/comment/pby2zot/	It's never really one thing, just always something. It's lonely as a small business owner in the sense where I have no one to share my struggles with. It even crosses into being able to share my vision with others for support in strategic thinking. You almost get imposter syndrome that can cripple you at times from mak...

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R22	r/smallbusiness 2025-08-22 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1mxbmgq/comment/na3qbxw/	Dance studio. They own a successful dance studio about 8x the size of mine, and the owner does business consulting. I've followed the owner for about two years and was very much looking forward to this. I think the issue is that a lot of studio owners don't know what the hell they're doing; they're creatives, not bus...
R23	r/smallbusiness 2025-08-22 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1mxbmgq/comment/na3st9r/	The problem is often going to someone with too much experience in common with your own business. Business owners usually only look to consultants with direct experience of their type of business when 99% of business problems are generic business issues. On the flip side, at least half the time a business owner hires...
R24	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-21 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rzmvmvx/comment/obpzopo/	Having been through this exact transition, here's what I found actually moves people to pull the trigger on a coach. The decision is almost never logical. It's a pain threshold thing. People don't hire a coach when things are going well. They hire one when something broke, they're stuck, or they're about to make a big...
R25	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-21 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rzmvmvx/comment/obn23t6/	I would only ever consider someone who's actually operated at a successful level - built a successful business (not in coaching). That usually isn't compatible with the career cos people who've built a successful business don't tend to work as a coach.
R26	r/smallbusiness 2026-03-21 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1rzmvmvx/comment/obn4758/	most owners don't wake up wanting "a business coach." they wake up wanting a specific mess to stop costing them money. if your positioning still sounds like accountability, mindset, clarity, etc, a lot of people will mentally dump you in the same pile as generic linkedin gurus. harsh, but that's the category problem. ...
R27	r/Femalefounders 2026-09-12 https://www.reddit.com/r/Femalefounders/comments/1we8w3c/	Looking to assemble a small mastermind of ~10 female founders to support each other (complementary skills) :: **TL;dr: Putting together a tight-knit mastermind group of ten-ish serious female founders/specialists.** I saw a post floating around about skipping huge, noisy 2,000-person communities in favor of a small "s...
R28	r/Femalefounders 2026-09-12 https://www.reddit.com/r/Femalefounders/comments/1we8w3c/comment/p9gyfek/	Hi! Love this idea, thanks for pitching it. 10+ years building a brand product business, with experience in brand marketing, ecomm website design / Shopify, klaviyo email marketing, managing a tiny team, but my focus expertise is probably organic social media and building a community of customers through it. I'm look...
R29	r/Femalefounders 2026-09-12 https://www.reddit.com/r/Femalefounders/comments/1we8w3c/comment/p9ld8f4/	wait I actually LOVE this idea 🥰 I'm building a women's health/femtech startup We're early stage but already have a product + customers, and I'm currently focused on figuring out growth + scaling My background is in digital business, branding/marketing, consumer behaviour + strategy, and I'm definitely more of a big...
R30	r/smallbusiness 2026-02-04 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1qvyahc/comment/o3nfibq/	Sounds like a mastermind group of some sort. I went through a bootcamp type program sponsored by one of the big investment banks. It was good stuff, but the most valuable thing about it was that I made friends with several of the other business owners in our group. It was across all industries, so lots of different i...
R31	r/smallbusiness 2025-10-12 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1o4b9dl/	I've been stuck at \$200k in revenue for three years now :: It's becoming very frustrating. My buddy and I started this business from nothing, and it felt like we would be well off fairly quickly. Our first full year, we hit almost 200k. Seemed like the sky was the limit. We make a product and sell both online and in pe...

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R32	r/smallbusiness 2026-05-19 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1tha6ya/	26 years in a niche small business. Stuck at \$300K. Ready to scale. Where do I start? :: I've run a niche, experience-based small business for 26 years. We sit around \$300K in revenue and have for a while — steady, loyal customer base, 5-star reputation locally, but margins have been squeezed hard over the last few yea...
R33	r/smallbusiness 2025-03-05 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1j43bvt/	Service Business Stuck at \$1.5m Revenue :: My business has been stuck around the \$1.5m revenue mark for the past 4 years. I've been in business for about 8-9 years. It's a moving company. We're doing SEO, we have 3 locations on GBP (so more people on google can find us in other locations), we're doing sales training, w...
R34	r/smallbusiness 2025-03-05 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1j43bvt/comment/mg596sd/	Missing an operator. Someone who's taken a business from \$1M to \$2-5M
R35	r/smallbusiness 2025-12-11 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1pjyb43/	Anyone else feel STUCK in their own business? :: Hello, I'm new here. My name's Gary. I'm in my late 50s and, to put it bluntly, **I feel 'stuck' inside my own business**. At the risk of sounding defeatist, I feel like I'm in a fun-free loop, grinding slowly towards failure. For over a decade I've run my own small vid...
R36	r/smallbusiness 2025-12-11 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1pjyb43/comment/ntj4fqo/	I struggle with it. I'm the last man standing at my small family business in the sense that everyone that was with me when we started my stone engraving company has either died or left. I've got a great guy over on the production end, and my mom essentially volunteers for us full time and my wife gets a steady payche...
R37	r/smallbusiness 2026-05-23 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1tl89p3/	How do you know if you are actually growing, or just stuck in a loop? :: I've been running my business for a few years now. Lately, I've been feeling completely stuck and honestly, pretty exhausted. My daily schedule is packed. I spend my whole day dealing with sales issues, resolving team conflicts, and handling cli...
R38	r/smallbusiness 2026-05-23 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1tl89p3/comment/oojqvfv/	Exact situation I was in around 2017. Working long days and handling everything, the end of the month looked identical to last month. Busy wasn't the same as growing, and I could feel that but couldn't articulate it. The difference I eventually found in a growth phase is you're solving new problems. In a loop, you're s...
R39	r/Entrepreneur 2025-12-22 https://www.reddit.com/r/Entrepreneur/comments/1ptdgzk/	I've hit a plateau in my business and don't know how to get out. What do I do? :: I own a dance studio, and I've hit a plateau. Since August, I've just been building infrastructure. I hired a studio manager to run the desk, handle inquiries, organization, and customer service. I hired a director to manage teachers...
R40	r/smallbusiness 2025-02-25 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1iy0jch/comment/meqgt6n/	The thing is I already have people working for me, yet I'm still pulling crazy hours everyday because I can't trust someone else to do my work... if that makes sense?
R41	r/smallbusiness 2026-05-24 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1tmhkoq/	Does anyone else feel stuck in the “hire help → lose profit → take it back on yourself” cycle? :: How are small businesses supposed to grow without hiring people to manage social media and administrative support? These honestly feel like the two biggest time-sucking areas in a small business. Genuinely asking. Every t...
R42	r/smallbusiness 2026-05-24 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1tmhkoq/comment/onne7og/	We've been working on automating administrative tasks and easily repeatable client work. It's allowed us to shave one or two positions that were high turnover and generally money losers. We've outsourced dev work to another company (never using freelancers again). The only real solution we found though is to charge mor...

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R43	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-31 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1vbm3dm3/comment/p0uf9r8/	One thing I do is take Sundays off, the best I can. Its for house stuff and family stuff. I try for Saturday too, but that unrealistic for me. One day, when the business runs itself, it'll be all worth it.
R44	r/smallbusiness 2026-08-14 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1v0e65y/	How are you all handling marketing when you don't have time or budget to hire an agency? :: Running a solo business and I keep hitting the same wall: I know I should be doing more consistent marketing — knowing what competitors are actually doing, finding people who'd refer me work, posting regularly instead of in burs...
R45	r/Entrepreneur 2025-07-09 https://www.reddit.com/r/Entrepreneur/comments/1lvvaxg/comment/n299w2j/	Your husband is an investor in this equation so why not treat him like that. What do you do when an investor denies the funding? You don't try to sway them. You find another one.
R46	r/EtsySellers 2026-07-15 https://www.reddit.com/r/EtsySellers/comments/1ux9pdc/comment/oxpf2sn/	Raise the price more and extend your processing time. Don't burn yourself out to the point you hate your shop and want to close it down.
R47	r/smallbusiness 2026-07-30 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1valsnd/comment/p0mtiet/	I worked with one through my state's Small Business Development Center. Most state's have something like this. She helped me with all the legal compliance, getting payroll setup, basics of running a business, stuff like that. We meet virtually every 6 months now and she basically gives me advice, or points me to s...
R48	r/Entrepreneur 2026-09-23 https://www.reddit.com/r/Entrepreneur/comments/1wo3oud/comment/pbpm86g/	Sounds like you have had a really good experience with him. Five years of networking and multiple referrals says a lot more than a random recommendation. Finding someone who is genuinely good at what they do and also a solid person is pretty rare.
R49	r/EtsySellers 2025-05-24 https://www.reddit.com/r/EtsySellers/comments/1ku0p15/	How to deal with burnout? :: I've been doing my best to promote my Etsy and stuff but I'm just so tried, I barely,y get any views a I've been getting more recently but no sales and I'm just so sad and tired. I want to try running ads on insta and Etsy when I have the cash, but I post a lot on instagram already and idk ...
R50	r/smallbusiness 2026-08-17 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1vqvjkh/	Small business blew up on social media, getting overwhelmed. :: Hey guys, we started a small business a couple months ago, it involves doing a monthly drop of a limited amount of handmade items. The first month was slow, no followers, a couple sales, going off Etsy. We had a video blow up on Facebook and got around 40k...
R51	r/smallbusiness 2025-09-27 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1ns3nsv/comment/ngjfnn5/	That's because this is an ad for a crappy AI subscription. [note: commenter calling out a disguised ad; the parent thread is excluded as buyer evidence]
R52	r/smallbusiness 2025-04-01 https://www.reddit.com/r/smallbusiness/comments/1jp0pvn/comment/mkw9h7o/	I found Denver Business Coach by researching and asking people for advice. I wanted a coach with real experience, not just big promises. I read reviews, checked their success stories, and talked to them to see if they were a good fit. What I liked most was that they really listened to me. They didn't just give general ... [note: ASTROTURF: account promoting one coaching firm, called out by other commenters (see R10); kept only as an example of what is excluded]
T01	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/actioncoach.com	4.8/5, 88 reviews, 90% five-star; no 2-4 star text visible; themes: revenue growth claims, multi-year relationships
T02	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/helloseven.co	2.9/5, 2 reviews, both 1-star (Feb 2024): mastermind sales 'bait and switch'; 'superficial and short'; founder rarely present; coaches slow to respond

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T03	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/femaleentrepreneurassociation.com	4.8/5, 331 reviews; praise for support and community; complaints about overwhelming amount of information
T04	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/tonyrobbins.com	2-star and 3-star (2026-07-28): could not reach anyone before buying; high-pressure 'offers right now', 'no adequate support'
T05	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/vistage.com	0 reviews (closest structural peer: monthly peer-advisory groups)
T06	trustpilot https://www.trustpilot.com/review/strategiccoach.com	0 reviews
OB1	own-buyer file://BUSINESS-MEMORY.md#THE-BUYER	jewelry, ~2.5 yrs, targeting ~\$100K; considering wholesale, PR, influencers, pop-ups; 'let me think about it, and I, like, really want to sit down also with my husband'; 'this fall is, like, so big, and has so many opportunities'
GT1	ground-truth file://research/GROUND-TRUTH.md	owner-reported beliefs and facts about Founder Forum; beliefs are hypotheses, facts are the business's own
C01	last30days-collector file://raw/business-coach-worth-it-small-business-owner-raw.md	Reddit 9, YouTube 3, HN 10; mostly off-topic padding; surfaced r/Entrepreneur 'Business coach or therapist??' and r/Femalefounders 'Mom business coach?'
G01-G14	google autocomplete (US, English)	Seeds queried: business coach for women; business coach worth; mastermind for women business owners; how to grow my small business; how to scale a small business; too busy to grow my business; small business owner burnout; should i hire a business coach; should i hire a marketing agency; interior design business coach; jewelry business coach; how to get more customers for my small business; small business growth plan; peer advisory group small business. Shows that related searches exist; carries no volume.